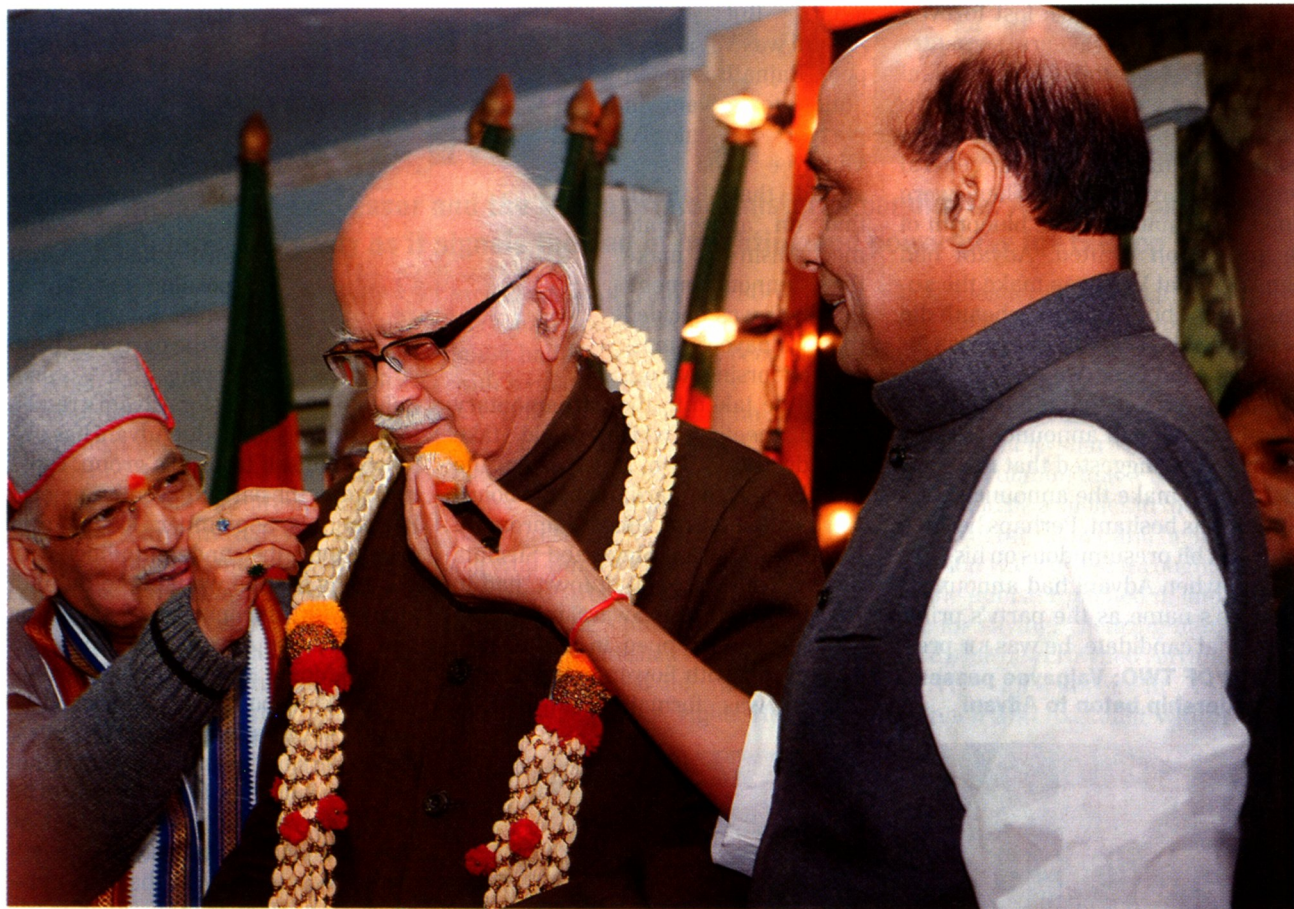




Advani's prime ministerial ambitions have been won over. Advani's men like to believe that his Jinnah gamble has paid off. The allies don't see him as an untouchable anymore. But in reality it was only three months back that Nitish Kumar had rejected Advani's candidature. However, now with Vajpayee out of the equation, he has realised that he has little choice. Moreover, Advani has always been the master of coalitions. It was he who brought the Shiv Sena and other allies on board in the first place.

Moreover, NDA needs a leader. While Vajpayee had been slowly withdrawing from active politics, Advani had been loth to take charge. He instead preferred to play by the rule book, and stuck to his role as the Leader of Opposition, guiding BJP instead of the entire NDA.

The intense infighting within BJP didn't help consolidate opposition politics either. Despite all its strictures against the personality cult, the parivar has realised that the party needs a strong leader. Historically, this has been the norm. Initially Shyama Prasad Mookerjee's word was law; he

was followed by Deen Dayal Upadhyaya till 1968 after which Vajpayee took charge. In the early nineties, after Advani's *Somnath rath yatra* the party slipped into dual control managed by the two. This continued until Advani went over to Pakistan in June 2005 and tried to reinvent himself. After that, crippled by RSS, Advani slipped into the background. Rajnath tried to assert himself but soon became a victim of the infighting.

Advani's nomination had been a foregone conclusion for some time now. He had also been dropping hints, talking about the Westminster model

TASTE OF SUCCESS: Advani being greeted by Joshi (left) and Rajnath

whereby the leader of the party is the prime ministerial candidate. The party seems to agree. His 80th birthday bash in Delhi on November 9 turned into a *shakti-pradarshan* (show of strength) with a galaxy of BJP chief ministers and senior leaders flying in for the occasion. Later, an Anup Jalota evening on his wife's birthday saw RSS's top honchos, Bhagwat and K. Sudarshan seated at Advani's dining table.

In many senses, this signals the end of the Vajpayee era. The party patriarch has now signed off from active politics. He will play an advisory role, seeking votes on his letterhead, but it is now clearly Advani's tryst with destiny. After the 2004 Lok Sabha loss he had lamented that the party had lost touch with its core constituency. It is now his task to woo that vote bank back. But tomorrow is another day. Sitting in his study a day after his nomination, receiving calls and well wishers, BJP's candidate for prime minister in-waiting had a relaxed smile on his face. His wait is finally over. ■

**Advani has
Vajpayee and the
Sangh's blessings
along with the
approval of NDA**